Political Parties

The big idea

Political parties are the most visible institution in a democracy. For most ordinary citizens, democracy is equal to political parties. Yet parties are also among the least trusted institutions. This chapter explains **what parties are, what they do, why we need them, the kinds of party systems, India's national and state parties, and the challenges and reforms** of party politics.

POLITICAL PARTY

A group of people who come together to **contest elections and hold power in the government**. They agree on some policies and programmes for society with a view to promote the collective good. A party is known by **which part it stands for, which policies it supports and whose interests it upholds**.
A political party has **three components**: (1) the **leaders**, (2) the **active members**, (3) the **followers**.

Functions of political parties

1. **Contest elections**: in most democracies, elections are fought mainly among candidates put up by parties. In some countries like the **USA**, members and supporters of a party choose its candidates; in India, **top party leaders** choose candidates.
2. **Put forward different policies and programmes**: voters choose from them. A party reduces a vast variety of opinions into a few basic positions that it supports. A government is expected to base its policies on the line taken by the ruling party.

3. **Make laws**: formally, laws are debated and passed in the legislature, but since most members belong to a party, they go by the direction of the party leadership.
4. **Form and run governments**: parties recruit leaders, train them and make them ministers to run the government as they want.
5. **Play the role of opposition**: parties that lose elections voice different views, criticise the government for its failures or wrong policies, and mobilise opposition to the government.
6. **Shape public opinion**: they raise and highlight issues. Parties have lakhs of members and activists spread all over the country; many of their pressure groups are extensions of parties among different sections of society. They often launch movements for resolution of problems faced by people.
7. **Provide access to government machinery and welfare schemes**: for an ordinary citizen, it is easy to approach a local party leader than a government officer. Party leaders feel close to people even when people do not fully trust them.

Why do we need parties?

Without parties, every candidate in elections would be **independent**. No one would be able to make any promises to the people about major policy changes; the government may be formed, but its utility would remain uncertain. Elected representatives would be accountable to their constituency for what they do in the locality, but **no one would be responsible for how the country is run**. The rise of political parties is directly linked to the emergence of **representative democracies**. Large-scale societies need representative democracy; parties gather different views on various issues and present them to the government. They bring various representatives together so that a responsible government can be formed, and they support or restrain the government.

NON-PARTY ELECTIONS

In many states, **panchayat elections** are not fought on party lines. But villages often split into factions that put up a "panel" of candidates, which is exactly what a party does.

Party systems

Type	Meaning	Example
One-party system	Only one party is allowed to control and run the government	**China** (Communist Party of China). Not a good option for democracy because voters have no free choice.
Two-party system	Power usually changes between two main parties; several other parties may exist and contest, but only the two main parties have a serious chance of winning a majority	**USA, United Kingdom**
Multi-party system	Several parties compete for power, and more than two parties have a reasonable chance of coming to power either on their own strength or in alliance with others	**India**

When several parties in a multi-party system join hands to contest elections and win power, it is called an **alliance or a front**. In India, there were three such major alliances in the 2004 parliamentary elections: the **National Democratic Alliance (NDA)**, the **United Progressive Alliance (UPA)** and the **Left Front**. Multi-party systems often appear messy and lead to political instability, but they allow a **variety of interests and opinions** to enjoy political representation.

Why India has a multi-party system: no system is ideal for all countries; party systems evolve over a long time depending on the nature of society, its social and regional divisions, its history of politics and its system of elections. India is a

large country with **social and geographical diversity**, which is not easily absorbed by two or even three parties.

PARTISANSHIP

Partisan means a person who is strongly committed to a party, group or faction. Partisanship is marked by a tendency to take a side and an inability to take a balanced view on an issue. Participation in party activities in India has been increasing over the decades; the proportion of people who say they are members of some party has gone up.

National and state parties

Every party in the country has to **register** with the **Election Commission**. While the Commission treats all parties equally, it offers some special facilities to large and established parties: they are given a **unique symbol**, which only official candidates of that party can use. Parties that get this privilege are **"recognised" parties**.

RECOGNITION CRITERIA

- **State party**: a party that secures at least **six per cent of the total votes in an election to the Legislative Assembly of a State** and wins at least **two seats**.
- **National party**: a party that secures at least **six per cent of the total votes in Lok Sabha elections or Assembly elections in four States** and wins at least **four seats in the Lok Sabha**.

National parties (NCERT lists eight as of 2019; after the Election Commission's review in **April 2023**, six are recognised):

Party	Founded	Key points
Indian National Congress (INC)	**1885**	One of the oldest parties of the world; played a dominant role in Indian politics at national and state

Party	Founded	Key points
		level for several decades after independence; a centrist party, supports secularism and welfare of weaker sections and minorities.
Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)	**1980**	Founded by reviving the **Bharatiya Jana Sangh** (formed by **Syama Prasad Mukherjee** in **1951**). Wants to build a strong and modern India by drawing inspiration from India's ancient culture and values; cultural nationalism (Hindutva) is an important element.
Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)	**1984**	Formed under the leadership of **Kanshi Ram**. Seeks to represent and secure power for the bahujan samaj (dalits, adivasis, OBCs and religious minorities); draws inspiration from the ideas of Sahu Maharaj, Mahatma Phule, Periyar Ramaswami Naicker and Babasaheb Ambedkar. Main base in **Uttar Pradesh**.
Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI-M)	**1964**	Believes in Marxism-Leninism; supports socialism, secularism and democracy, opposes imperialism and communalism. Strong support in **West Bengal, Kerala and Tripura**.
National People's Party (NPP)	**2013**	Formed under the leadership of **P.A. Sangma**; the first political party from the **north-east** to attain national party status.
Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)	**2012**	Recognised as a national party in April 2023.

(Your textbook edition may also list the **Communist Party of India (CPI, 1925)**, **Nationalist Congress Party (NCP, 1999)** and **All India Trinamool Congress (AITC, 1998)**, which were national parties as of 2019.)

State parties (commonly called regional parties) are not necessarily regional in ideology; some are all-India parties that happen to succeed only in some states (e.g., Samajwadi Party, Rashtriya Janata Dal). Others like the **Biju Janata Dal,**

Sikkim Democratic Front, Mizo National Front and Telangana Rashtra Samithi are conscious about their state identity. Over the last three decades, the number and strength of state parties have expanded, making the Parliament more diverse; no national party is able to secure a majority on its own in some elections, so national parties are compelled to form alliances with state parties. This has contributed to strengthening **federalism and democracy**.

Challenges to political parties

1. **Lack of internal democracy**: all over the world, there is a tendency for power to concentrate in one or a few top leaders. Parties do not keep membership registers, do not hold organisational meetings or conduct internal elections regularly. Ordinary members do not get sufficient information about what happens inside the party; those who disagree with leadership find it difficult to continue.
2. **Dynastic succession**: since most parties do not practise open and transparent procedures, there are very few ways for an ordinary worker to rise to the top. Those who happen to be the leaders are in a position of unfair advantage to favour people close to them or family members. In many parties, top positions are always controlled by members of one family.
3. **Growing role of money and muscle power**: since parties are focused only on winning elections, they tend to use short-cuts. They nominate candidates who have or can raise lots of money. Rich people and companies who give funds tend to influence policies and decisions. In some cases, parties support **criminals** who can win elections.
4. **Lack of meaningful choice**: in recent years there has been a decline in ideological differences among parties in most parts of the world. Those who want really different policies have no option available; sometimes people cannot even elect very different leaders, because the same set of leaders keep shifting from one party to another.

How can parties be reformed?

Recent efforts:

- The Constitution was amended to prevent elected MLAs and MPs from changing parties (**anti-defection law**). If any MLA or MP changes parties, he or she will **lose the seat** in the legislature. This has helped bring defection down, but it has made dissent even more difficult: MPs and MLAs have to accept whatever the party leaders decide.
- The **Supreme Court** passed an order to reduce the influence of money and criminals: now it is mandatory for every candidate who contests elections to file an **affidavit giving details of his property and criminal cases** pending against him. The new system has made a lot of information available to the public, though there is no system to check if the information given is true.
- The **Election Commission** passed an order making it necessary for political parties to **hold their organisational elections and file their income tax returns**. Parties have started doing so, but it is sometimes a mere formality.

Suggestions often made:

- A **law to regulate the internal affairs** of political parties: maintain a register of members, follow its own constitution, have an independent authority to act as judge in case of party disputes, hold open elections to the highest posts.
- Make it mandatory for parties to give a minimum number of tickets, about **one-third, to women candidates**; similarly a quota for women in decision-making bodies of the party.
- **State funding of elections**: the government should give parties money to support their election expenses, in kind (petrol, paper, telephone) or cash, on the basis of votes secured in the last election.

Two other ways: **people can put pressure** on parties through petitions, publicity and agitations (pressure groups, media); and **political parties can improve if those who want this join them**. It is difficult to change democracy if ordinary citizens do not take part and simply criticise from outside.

RECOGNITION CRITERIA MIX-UP

State party: **6% votes in a state assembly election + 2 seats**. National party: **6% votes in Lok Sabha or assembly elections in four states + 4 Lok Sabha seats**. Students often swap 2 and 4.

BOARD FAVOURITES

"Functions of political parties" (5 marks), "Why do we need political parties?", "Explain one-party, two-party and multi-party systems", "Challenges faced by political parties" (5 marks), "Steps taken / suggestions to reform parties", "Criteria for a national/state party". Be ready to describe any one national party in 3 points.

Quick recap

- A party: a group that contests elections to hold power; components are leaders, active members and followers.
- Functions: contest elections, put forward policies, make laws, form governments, act as opposition, shape opinion, give access to welfare.
- Party systems: one-party (China), two-party (USA, UK), multi-party (India); alliances like NDA, UPA, Left Front.
- Recognition by the Election Commission: state party (6% + 2 seats), national party (6% in LS or 4 states + 4 LS seats).
- Challenges: no internal democracy, dynastic succession, money and muscle power, no meaningful choice.
- Reforms: anti-defection law, affidavits, organisational elections and tax returns; suggested law on internal affairs, women's quota, state funding.

Practice questions

1. Which of these is NOT a component of a political party?
   (a) Leaders (b) Active members (c) Followers (d) Election Commission officials
2. China has a
   (a) one-party system (b) two-party system (c) multi-party system (d) coalition system
3. To be recognised as a state party, a party must secure at least
   (a) 4% votes and one seat (b) 6% votes in four states and four Lok Sabha seats (c) 6% of votes in a state assembly election and win at least two seats (d) 10% votes in the Lok Sabha
4. The Bahujan Samaj Party was formed in 1984 under the leadership of
   (a) Syama Prasad Mukherjee (b) P.A. Sangma (c) B.R. Ambedkar (d) Kanshi Ram
5. Under the anti-defection law, an MP or MLA who changes parties
   (a) gets a ministerial post (b) must contest a by-election within one month (c) loses the seat in the legislature (d) is banned from politics for life
6. The first political party from the north-east to attain national party status is the
   (a) Mizo National Front (b) Asom Gana Parishad (c) National People's Party (d) Sikkim Democratic Front
7. "The same set of leaders keep shifting from one party to another" points to which challenge?
   (a) Dynastic succession (b) Lack of internal democracy (c) Money and muscle power (d) Lack of meaningful choice
8. Why do modern democracies need political parties? Give three reasons.
9. Describe any five challenges faced by political parties in India and suggest how they can be reformed.

Answers: 1. d 2. a 3. c 4. d 5. c 6. c 7. d 8. see notes 9. see notes